

Google and Facebook most visited

According to Opera's State of the Mobile Web report 2010, Google emerged as the top site surfed on mobile web

Mac App Store comin soon

The Mac App store will go live for business on January 6, 2011

Web Awards 2010

Team Digit
readersletters@thinkdigit.com



and News. The other 6 categories will be posted as an ongoing series on our web site, www.thinkdigit.com.

HOW WE TESTED

Like everything else in digit, we were extremely fastidious about the way we conducted our testing. The first step was to identify the contenders for each of the categories, we didn't want to miss out on identifying any player no matter how small. But after identifying the players we quickly sorted the wheat

from the chaff and started a stringent test process. A common set of tests were drawn up, such as, load time, W3C compliance, search quality, ease of navigation, browser compatibility etc. and each web site rigorously rated on each test parameter. But since each category was unique in itself we went about defining 'depth' for each category. For instance to quantify Gaming, we gave scores for community interactivity, availability of multiplayer games, quality of games, submit game option, leaderboards etc. The same was done for each category of web site. So now without further ado lets start off with the Digit Web Awards 2010.

GAMING

Online gaming has been growing by leaps and bounds over the last decade, and the continued development of Flash and other frameworks have contributed to the general ease of accessibility, for people of all ages. The platforms, frameworks, browsers and internet speeds are advancing so fast in fact, that the near future may hold the majority of games in the online space, from casual games to full fledged mammoths. Keeping these and other factors in mind, we decided to not restrict ourselves to only Indian web sites for this category. After all gaming is universal and as a service is not location dependent.

When discussing casual gaming portals for our Web Awards of 2010 with this broader outlook, the first site that popped into our minds was Miniclip.com, presumably a strong contender. But as we progressed through our well-structured test processes for Web Awards, we started to realise another, much newer, site was making a much bigger splash than Miniclip.com, a splash that went far beyond the

metrics we were applying, all the way from the site's overall design to its community interactivity and freshness.

Started in June 2006 by a brother and sister duo named Emily and Jim Greer, Kongregate was released to the general public in December 2006, and officially entered beta testing in late-March 2007, and hasn't looked back since. In fact, it became so popular that the game retailing behemoth, GameStop, acquired the company in July of 2010.

Kongregate had over 36,000 free online games divided across 10 categories on its site when we began writing this article, and while sheer diversity was a big factor when scoring the portals, perhaps the best thing about the site is how it is actually built around the games' developers and users themselves, with very strong builder/player community ties.

While five out of the six sites (Miniclip, Zapak, AddictingGames, Pogo, Kongregate, FreeOnlineGames) in our line-up

had the option for users to submit a game, Kongregate accepts only user-created Adobe Flash or Adobe Director games, and, also provides developers with an API to help integrate scores, leaderboards, and achievement badges on a site-wide basis.

This seriously ups the potential for long-time playability, something nearly unheard of in online Flash games. Users want to increase their reputation and level up, similar to an MMO, except this is site-wide, and not restricted to just one game, though of course, each game has its own leaderboards. Accomplish game-

